

BOLIVIA AND PARAGUAY



BOLIVIA AND PARAGUAY are the only land-locked countries in South America. They are also two of the poorest in the continent, reliant on their neighbours for access to the sea. In a

bitter war (1932–35) between them over ownership of the Gran Chaco, Bolivia lost, but both countries suffered political turmoil. Under Spanish rule between the 1530s and 1820s, Bolivia and Paraguay still bear its legacy: Spanish is an official language, and more than 90 per cent of the region's population is Roman Catholic. Many people farm and, in Bolivia, some grow and sell coca for cocaine, a drug that the government has taken steps to banish.

Physical features

The Altiplano dominates the west of Bolivia, while the east is covered by a lowland plain called the Oriente. Paraguay is divided north to south by the Paraguay River. In the west is the Gran Chaco, a region of grass and scrub; the east is covered in grassy plains and forests, and drained by the mighty Paraná River.



Altiplano

At about 3,800 m (12,467 ft) above sea-level, the Altiplano, a vast, windswept, almost treeless plateau, lies between two ranges of the Bolivian Andes. Despite its cold, arid climate, more than half of Bolivia's population lives here, growing a few crops and rearing animals such as llamas and alpacas.



Lake Titicaca

The clear blue waters of Lake Titicaca cover 8,288 sq km (3,200 sq miles) at a height of 3,810 m (12,500 ft) above sea-level, making it the highest navigable lake in the world. It is the last surviving stretch of an ancient inland sea known as Lago Ballivián.



Gran Chaco

The flat, dry plain that covers southeastern Bolivia and northwest Paraguay is called the Gran Chaco. Since so few people live in this region of coarse grass, thorny shrubs, and cactus, a wide range of plants and animals thrives here.

Regional climate

Bolivia's Altiplano has a cool, crisp, dry climate. The eastern part of the country is warm and humid, as is most of Paraguay. The Chaco is hot, with 50–100 cm (20–40 in) of rain a year, although it often has droughts in winter.

Aymara

The Aymara are a group of native South Americans who have farmed on the Bolivian Altiplano for hundreds of years, strongly resisting cultural change. With the Quechua, another native group, they make up more than half of Bolivia's population, but suffer discrimination and do not contribute to politics or the economy. The state has successfully persuaded many Aymara to move into towns.



Aymara farmers, Altiplano, Bolivia

